

Malachi

The last prophet of the Old Testament, who called a tired people back to God and promised a messenger to prepare the way.

Malachi spoke to Judah about a century after the first exiles came home. The temple stood, but the excitement was gone. Priests offered blind and sick animals, husbands broke faith with their wives, and people held back their tithes. Malachi answered with sharp conversations: God speaks, the people push back with "Wherein?", and God explains. Beneath the rebukes is a tender message: "I have loved you, saith the LORD." He promised a messenger to prepare the way and pointed to Elijah, a promise the New Testament sees fulfilled in John the Baptist.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Mal'akhi</i> , "my messenger"; perhaps a title
Family	Not given
When	Probably c. 430 BC, near Nehemiah's time (rough)
Audience	Priests and people of Judah under a Persian governor (Mal 1:8)
Style	Usually counted as six "disputes" answering "Wherein?"
Last words	A promise to send "Elijah the prophet" (Malachi 4:5–6)
New Testament	Quoted of John the Baptist (Mark 1:2; Luke 1:17) and Romans 9:13

"Behold, I will send my messenger, and he shall prepare the way before me: and the Lord, whom ye seek, shall suddenly come to his temple ... saith the LORD of hosts."

Malachi 3:1, KJV

The life of Malachi

Malachi gives no dates and no personal details. Most place him c. 430 BC because the temple is standing, a governor rules, and he deals with the same problems Nehemiah faced. The entries below set his message in its setting.

c. 516/515 BC

Before Malachi

● The temple rebuilt

The second temple is finished and dedicated with joy, and the priests and Levites are set in their places. More than eighty years later, Malachi speaks to the priests who serve at its altar. *Ezra 6:15–18*

c. 445/444 BC

Before Malachi

● A covenant signed

Under Nehemiah and Ezra, the people promise in writing not to intermarry with idol worshippers, to bring their firstfruits and tithes, and not to neglect God's house. Malachi's hearers have broken these promises. *Nehemiah 10:28–39*

**c. 430 BC
(rough)**

*Malachi's
ministry*

● Broken promises

Malachi confronts careless priests, blemished sacrifices, broken marriages, marriage to idol worshippers and withheld tithes. These are the same sins Nehemiah fought on his return, which is why many date the two men close together. *Malachi 1:6–2:16; 3:7–10; Nehemiah 13:10–29*

**c. 430 BC
(rough)**

*Malachi's last
words*

● Remember and wait

Malachi urges the people to remember the law of Moses and promises that Elijah the prophet will come before the great day of the Lord, to turn the hearts of fathers and children to each other. *Malachi 4:4–6*

**About four
centuries
later**

● The messenger announced

An angel tells the priest Zechariah (Zacharias in the KJV) that his son John will go before the Lord "in the spirit and power of Elias," just as Malachi foretold. *Luke 1:13–17*

Key activities

Some scholars think "Malachi" is a title, "my messenger," taken from Malachi 3:1, rather than the prophet's name. The Greek Old Testament translates it as "his messenger." An old Jewish tradition identified Malachi with Ezra. Most readers simply take it as the prophet's name.

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- 1 Declared God's love.** He began with God's words, "I have loved you," and answered the people's doubt about it. *Malachi 1:2-5*
 - 2 Rebuked worthless offerings.** He told the priests they would not dare offer blind and lame animals to their governor. *Malachi 1:6-14*
 - 3 Called priests back to their calling.** "The priest's lips should keep knowledge," for he is God's messenger. *Malachi 2:1-9*
 - 4 Defended faithful marriage.** He warned against breaking faith with "the wife of thy youth," for God "hateth putting away." *Malachi 2:13-16*
 - 5 Promised the Lord's coming.** God would send his messenger, and then come like "a refiner's fire." *Malachi 3:1-5*
 - 6 Called the people to return.** "Return unto me, and I will return unto you." He urged them to bring the whole tithe and test God's faithfulness. *Malachi 3:7-12*
 - 7 Encouraged the faithful.** Those who feared the Lord spoke together, and "a book of remembrance was written before him." *Malachi 3:16-18*
 - 8 Pointed to the dawn.** For those who fear God, "the Sun of righteousness" will rise "with healing in his wings." *Malachi 4:1-3*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Malachi. Tradition counts him the last prophet; the "four hundred silent years" before John is not a Bible phrase.

Old Testament

Malachi 1:1	The only verse that names him
Nehemiah 10:28–39; 13:10–29	The same problems in Nehemiah's day
Echo: Genesis 25:23; Isaiah 40:3	Jacob chosen; a voice preparing the way

New Testament

Matthew 11:10; Mark 1:2; Luke 7:27	Malachi 3:1 applied to John the Baptist
Luke 1:17	John comes "in the spirit and power of Elias"
Matthew 11:14; 17:10–13	Jesus says John is the Elijah to come
Romans 9:13	Paul quotes Malachi 1:2–3 on Jacob and Esau

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did the people answer when God said, "I have loved you" (Malachi 1:2)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God cared so much about the quality of the people's offerings (Malachi 1:6–14)?
3. *Apply:* Malachi's hearers had grown bored with God. Where has your faith become routine, and what could renew it?
4. *Apply:* Malachi 3:16 says the faithful "spoke often one to another." Who could you encourage in their faith this week?